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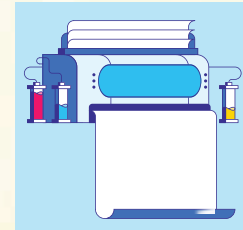
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COMMUNITY CORNER PARSHAS BEHAR-BECHUKOSAI בהר-בחוקתי



SHABBOS STARTS: 7:42 PM (18 MINUTES)

SHABBOS ENDS: 8:51 PM (50 MINUTES)

TZAIS HAKOCHAVIM: 9:12 PM (72 MINUTES)

Editor-in-chief: Doni Stern

Made possible by contributing writers throughout our community.

STORY OF THE WEEK By: Zechariah Lipitz



From all over Europe, thousands of Jews used to come to visit Reb Yisroel, the holy Rabbi of Ruzhin. For little Pesach, the orphan who had been taken in by the Rebbe's family, it was an amazing sight which he never became accustomed to - so many people with so many kinds of troubles - each with his own hopes for a better future.

"The Rebbe is a holy man," he was told. "All these people come to him for a blessing. When he gives it, he can see what will happen to them many years from now." One day the Rebbe called Pesach aside and told him, "A time will come when you will have to go away. You will study medicine and become a doctor. Then you shall go to the Holy Land. There is your place. And there you will save many lives." Pesach burst into tears. "Must I leave, Rebbe?" he cried.

"Don't be upset," the Rebbe said. "My thoughts will always be with you." And so it was that Pesach grew up and became a doctor - taking the family name of his beloved Rebbe, Friedman - and settling in Israel in the town of Tzefat in the Galilee. One day a regal carriage stopped in front of his house, and an important looking man stepped out. "I am looking for Dr. Friedman," he announced.

When Dr. Friedman came to the door he was told, "The Princess of Prussia is visiting Tzefat and she is extremely ill. One minute she is burning with fever, the next moment she is shivering with cold. You must come at once. Her father, the Kaiser, is anxious that you come at once."

Dr. Friedman hurried to the princess's bedside. He examined her and diagnosed malaria. "Take this medicine for three days. If we are fortunate, the disease has been caught in time for a cure."

Three days later the princess's fever broke, and it could be seen that she was on her way to recovery. After three weeks Dr. Friedman was summoned again. "The Princess will be resuming her trip; however she still feels weak and has begged that you come with her." Dr. Friedman explained, "Your Highness, it is difficult for me to fulfill your request. As a Jew I must pray three times a day with ten men, and I may eat only kosher food. The trip to Jerusalem is a long one."

The Kaiser replied, "Spare no expense. Bring along ten men and whatever food you require. Only come."

Dr. Friedman joined the traveling party for the long, arduous journey. When he finally returned home, his wife asked, "Did they reward you for saving the life of the princess?" "Not really, but they said the Kaiser would be in my debt. True, it was very difficult, but for me it is enough that I saved her life."

Many months passed and no more was heard from the princess or her father. The land of Israel was beset by problems, and the interesting episode of the princess was forgotten as everyone was consumed with a different worry - the safety of their children. The government of Turkey, which then ruled the Holy Land, was demanding that young Jewish men serve in its army. Not only was it impossible to observe the Torah in the army, but it was also highly dangerous. The only alternative was prison. Then, out of the blue, came a telegram for Dr. Friedman from the Kaiser of Prussia.

The brief cable stated that by the grace of His Royal Highness, the King of Prussia, Dr. Pesach Friedman had been appointed Consular Agent in Tzefat for the government of Prussia, with full authority to issue passports, visas, and any other such papers to citizens of Prussia.

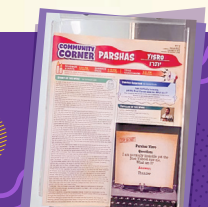
Dr. Friedman was silent for a long while, as he read and reread the telegram. Then, he remembered the words of his Rebbe, as if they had just been spoken, "There you will save many lives."

Hastily, he called a meeting of the communal leaders.

"Gentlemen," he announced, holding up the telegram, "here is the answer to our troubles. By this document I have been given the right to issue passports to citizens of Prussia. Do you realize what this means? No longer will the Turks have power over us. If any young men are threatened, let them come to me. I'll issue them a Prussian passport that will save them! With these papers they'll become citizens of Prussia and won't have to serve in the Turkish army!"

And so, the words of Reb Yisroel of Ruzhin came true over and over again!

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PARSHA QUESTION By: Gavriel Grodko

Which two events happened during Yovel?

Stay tuned for the answer in the next Community Corner issue

Answer to last weeks parsha question:

- Q. May the daughter of a kohen who had been previously married to a non-kohen eat from the Kodesh Hakodashim??
- A. Only if she has no children from her previous marriage.

THIS WEEK IN JEWISH HISTORY By: Avi Hirsch



The 2021 Meron tragedy was a devastating crowd crush on April 30, 2021, at Mount Meron, Israel, during the Lag BaOmer festival, resulting in 45 deaths and over 150 injuries. It is considered the deadliest civilian disaster in Israel's history. The incident was caused by extreme overcrowding, narrow passages, and slippery conditions on a sloping walkway, leading to a stampede. Four religious groups oversee different parts of the compound, with the Toldot Aharon running the part where the incident occurred. According to witness accounts, the event was held in a fenced area that was overly confined. At the time, the restricted area was filled with as many as 20,000 people. After the lighting ceremony, and as dancing began, hundreds of people left. The exit path was a narrow, steep slope with a smooth metal floor. As the crowd moved to the gates, a crush started. The crowd broke open side barriers of the path, creating rigged-up exits for some to break free.

As medics tried to reach the injured, former Israeli Chief Rabbi Yisrael Meir Lau remained on stage, urging calm and reciting psalms for the injured. Six helicopters were flown in to evacuate the injured. Cell phone service crashed due to the number of people trying to get in contact with their families. On 3 May 2021, the Israeli Authority for Sacred Locations had been given a decree requiring a permit from the Israeli police commissioner to hold any celebration.

Prior to the decree, only a permit from the regional police chief was required. In September 2021, Toldot Aharon announced that their annual Simchat Beit HaShoeivah, which normally attracts thousands of visitors, would be closed to the public to avoid overcrowding. As a result of the stampede, the pilgrimage on Lag BaOmer has undergone drastic changes beginning in 2022, including a limit on visitors at once, a maximum of four hours per person, and a requirement to purchase tickets beforehand.

A heavy military and police presence was also required by law.

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